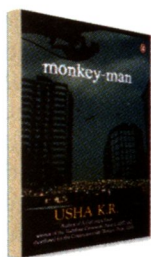


Closely KNIT

Two books stride through small town India, each weaving tales of confrontation

By Geeta Doctor



MONKEY-MAN

by USHA K.R.

Penguin

Price: Rs 299

Pages: 260

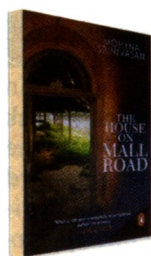
You've seen them on the catwalks of the country's pageants of beauty and fashion, the young women from small town India who shimmy their way to a metropolitan lifestyle. The rise of the stiletto socialites has been the stuff of aspirational fiction whether crime or chick-lit. This is true whether they are sold as brands that feed off the glamorous image of an author or as self-help manuals that impress upon the reader the importance of sex, shampoo, moolah and the methods of getting the right man, who will provide all three. Along the way, it's also helped to establish Mumbai as the New York of the Indian literary landscape, the only place where it appears reputations and sales figures might be allowed to soar.

Now you find the smaller towns competing with the mainstream. Are these the children of R. K. Narayan, the author who famously invented a small town in which to place his finely wrought cast of characters as an Usha K.R. introduces you to the daily rituals and dreams of the middle-classes who people her fiction, that are really memoirs of another way, another day in the ghettos of a city such as Bangalore? Or of first-time author Mohyna Srinivasan who reaches into the dusty pockets of Ambala, after carefully telling you where exactly you might find it on the map, if you don't happen to belong to an army background as she does and exorcises a moment that has all been forgotten in the shrapnel of the Indo-Pak war of 1971.

Let it be said at once that Usha is by now an old hand at crafting a story having won the 2007 Voda-

fone Crossword Award for the sinuously beautiful *A Girl and a River* that draws together family stories with the turmoil of growing up during the Independence period in small town Karnataka. Just as Bangalore is all grown up now, a fully fledged metropolis taking its cue from Mumbai, Usha has also grown up as a writer. It's not just a small inward looking family that she now examines, but a whole raft of characters who are cast adrift in a suburb. She uses a somewhat artificial *deus ex machina* in the form of a "Monkey-man", part a real menace that had once loomed across the urban landscape of certain inner cities of the subcontinent and part vehicle to prod her story into a suitably dramatic confrontation. What she's really good at is in invoking the dreams of the Indian middle class as it tried to snatch at the ideas, literary, political and societal during a time when being Indian was still a matter of dissent and debate. There is, however, a certain painstaking quality about her work that makes one think of a person, stringing different coloured beads together—for these are really short stories that are only coincidentally entwined—and holding them up for our approval. Each of the beads is, however, a beautifully polished gem.

Embroidery also comes to mind when one thinks of Srinivasan's tightly wrought world in the army cantonment of Ambala. She tells her story through the eyes of Parvathi Rana, who is apparently the only survivor of a midnight bomb that falls and destroys the house in which her mother and grandmother took shelter during the '71 war with Pakistan. It's a tale told with more passion than credibility demands but since it's a first, we shall love her just for that. ■



THE HOUSE ON MALL ROAD

by MOHYNA SRINIVASAN

Penguin

Price: Rs 325

Pages: 380

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